

The Half Portion

Act I

Scene 1

(The stage is set as a modest kitchen. FATAK, a boy of perhaps 12, is watching his MOTHER laboriously preparing chicken biryani. Steam rises.)

MOTHER

(whispering to herself)
Today, just one pot. Must make it enough.

FATAK

(eyes shining)
Biryani, Ma? Today?

MOTHER

(smiling)
Only for you, beta. Just for you.

FATAK

(joyful)
Yessss! Chicken biryani!

(MOTHER serves the biryani. FATAK eats slowly, savoring each bite.)

FATAK

(Mouth full)
This is the best thing in the world,
Ma. Better than anything.

MOTHER

(laughing gently)
Eat up. Finish it.

FATAK

(raising his glass)
And tea afterwards! Strong tea!

(Lights fade as FATAK enjoys his routine.)

Scene 2

(One week later. Afternoon. FATAK is eating his biryani in his corner, reading a book.)

FATAK

(to himself)
Same rice, same spices...
everyday...

(Suddenly, friends BILAL and KHAN burst in, energetic.)

BILAL

Hey! Game time!

KHAN

Let's play cricket!

FATAK

(excited)

Yes! Yes!

(KHAN throws the ball. It sails over the wall into the NEIGHBOUR'S compound.)

KHAN

Oops!

BILAL

Quick, get it!

FATAK hesitates, then goes to retrieve the ball. He stands by the wall, looking at the rice he left behind.)

FATAK

(silently, noticing a
NEIGHBOUR'S child sitting
nearby, eating plain rice
with a smile)

Just a little bit left...

(He picks up the ball, but his mind lingers on the plain rice.)

Scene 3

(Evening. FATAK is eating his biryani again, but this time, he looks troubled.)

FATAK

(to himself)

I eat biryani... every... single...
day.

(He looks at his plate. He stops eating.)

FATAK

(aloud, suddenly)

No. Not today. Not like this.

(MOTHER enters, concerned.)

MOTHER

Fatak? Is something wrong with the
food?

FATAK

(sincerely)

Ma... I... I think I've been eating
too much.

MOTHER

(confused)

But you love it so much!

FATAK

(serious)

I love it... but others... others
might not have anything like this.

MOTHER

(smiling softly)

You're a good boy. But don't starve
yourself, beta.

FATAK

I won't. I just... I want to change
something. From today...

(Fade to black.)

Act II

Scene 1

(Next morning. Kitchen. MOTHER is preparing biryani
again.)

MOTHER

(surprised)

Fatak? You're up early.

FATAK

(standing by the counter)

Ma. Today, can you make half the
amount?

MOTHER

(startled)

Half? Why?

FATAK

(resolute)

Because... if I eat half, then the
other half... it could help someone
else who doesn't get this everyday.
Like that boy I saw yesterday.

MOTHER

(eyes filling with tears)

You're growing up so fast, my son. A
promise like that... it means
something.

MOTHER

(serving half the portion)
Okay. But remember, sharing is beautiful, but don't forget to take care of yourself too.

FATAK

(nodding, eating slowly)
I will. Thank you, Ma.

(He finishes his half portion. He feels lighter, yet determined.)

Scene 2

(Schoolyard. FATAK is with BILAL and KHAN.)

BILAL

Where's your appetite today, Attack?
You eating half your biryani now?

FATAK

(smiling)
I am. Because... imagine if that little bit meant another person could have a meal.

KHAN

(astonished)
You don't seem sad about it. You seem... happy.

FATAK

It feels better. Like I'm doing something real.

BILAL

(grinning)
You're weird, Attack. But in a good way.

Scene 3

(One week passes. Evening. FATAK eats his half portion. He saves money.)

FATAK

(to himself)
If I save this money... what could I do?

(Fade to black.)

Act III

Scene 1

(Sunday. A community center. FATAK stands nervously with a bag of groceries.)

FATAK

(to a VOLUNTEER)

Um... I want to donate this food.

VOLUNTEER

(warmly)

Oh! You're Fatak! The biryani boy?
That's incredible. Where did this
come from?

FATAK

(proudly)

It's from my biryani. I eat half,
save half. For a week.

VOLUNTEER

(taking the bag)

This will feed a family today. Thank
you, Fatak. You're an inspiration.

FATAK

(teary-eyed)

Is it enough? Is it helping?

VOLUNTEER

(sincerely)

Every bit counts, Fatak. And your
thoughtfulness... that's worth more
than the food itself.

Scene 2

(Back home. MOTHER enters with a letter.)

MOTHER

(holding out a letter)

This came for you today.

FATAK

(opening it)

What is it?

(He reads. His eyes widen.)

FATAK

(excited)

It's a notice! The local community
is starting a food bank because of
what I did! They want to help more
people!

MOTHER

(hugging him tightly)

I knew your idea would grow wings,
beta.

Scene 3

(Months later. The community center is full. FATAK stands on a small stage.)

FATAK

(speaking to the crowd)

I used to think that my love for biryani was just about filling my own plate. But then I saw that a little bit of care could mean a lot to someone else. So I started eating half, to share the other half. And you... you showed me that half could become a feast for many.

(Crowd applauds.)

FATAK

(to himself, looking around)

Maybe one day, no one has to worry about their next meal.

(Curtain falls.)